

HORS D'OEUVRES **DILIP BOBB**

Loose Canons

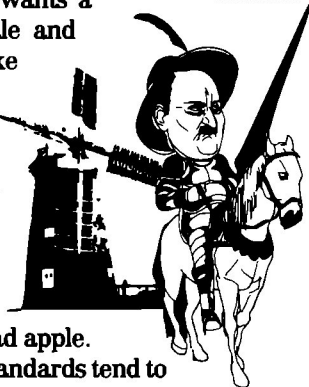


Morality is a tricky subject, open to different interpretations and varying levels of acceptance. Where it gets even trickier is when an individual seeks to thrust his personal morals down the collective throat by virtue of his official position. Whenever the post-mortem of the current Union Cabinet is conducted we may find the health minister heading the list of those who contributed the most to the UPA's mixed record and distorted image. Politics and history are riddled with people like Anbumani Ramadoss who sought to impose their personal value systems on a nation, ignoring issues like freedom of choice and the basic structure of a democracy.

No one can argue against his smoking ban in public places and even his controversial attempts to legalise homosexuality but his overall record in office shows the damage a loose cannon like Ramadoss can do when coalition politics gives him a free pass. Emboldened by his anti-tobacco campaign, he now wants a countrywide ban on the sale and consumption of alcohol. Unlike tobacco, alcohol is only harmful when it is taken in excess. In fact, every single global study so far has shown that alcohol in moderation is good for the heart. In that sense, the minister's proposal is like destroying the entire crop because of one bad apple.

People with high moral standards tend to believe their way of life is best for everyone. Former prime minister Morarji Desai was a prime example. Ramadoss, however, has a record that hardly allows him to offer umbrella edicts on health and enforcement. His spat with AIMS director P. Venugopal was transparently personal, as was his battle with Baba Ramdev—his ministry slapped a notice on the godman for claiming that yoga can cure various diseases. Later, he retracted his stand and endorsed everything the guru had said. He then took on Shah Rukh Khan and Amitabh Bachchan over his proposal to ban smoking scenes in films and teleserials. India is the only country in the world to propose such a ban.

In philosophy, the Ramadoss effect is called moral relativism. This holds that moral or ethical propositions do not reflect objective or universal moral truths, but instead relate to personal circumstances. Indeed, the universally accepted basis of modern civilisation calls for a morally neutral ground, a place of impartiality where no forcing of personal views are allowed and each individual takes a neutral posture towards the moral convictions of others. It's a prescription the minister would do well to follow instead of tilting at quixotic windmills.



SAURABH SINGH



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The Babus' Lost Miles

DELHI This could cut down on government officers' frequent travels abroad. The Department of Expenditure (DOE) issued new office memoranda first on September 23 and again on October 1, saying that air miles earned by officials will be utilised by the department concerned and not by the officials themselves.

This directive follows an INDIA TODAY story titled *Babus' Flights of Fancy* (September 15, 2008). The story highlighted how frequent flier mileage earned against official

trips are used for personal trips. The DOE stated, "Any usage of these mileage points for purposes of private travel by an officer will attract departmental action. This is to ensure that the benefits out of official travel, which is funded by the Government, should accrue to the Government". Officials have also been advised to travel in a class lower than their entitlements. These steps will certainly reduce the number of foreign trips made by government functionaries.

by Shyamal Yadav

To a Father's Rescue

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM Film director Maniratnam could have never imagined that his 16-year-old son Nandan's connections would come to his rescue one day. Maniratnam had to stop shooting *Ravanam*, his latest multi-lingual Abhishek Bachchan-Aishwarya Rai starrer in the forests near Kochi when forest officials ordered the crew to pack

up as they were found violating forest laws. "A violation by a VIP would attract more attention like the case of Salman Khan shooting a black buck," said a forest official. But urgent calls to LDF leaders from CPI(M) Politburo members ensured smooth shooting. The reason: Nandan was a much-noticed volunteer at the 19th CPI(M) Party Congress at Coimbatore in April. It certainly pays to be the father of an almost famous son.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan